



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: The Classical Academy

School Website: <https://www.classicalacademy.com/locations/the-classical-academy>

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Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

ACCS: ACCREDITED MEMBER SCL: MEMBER

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools (ACCS) and the Society for Classical Learning (SCL) is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Overall Classification: **CLASSICAL**

Executive Summary

The Classical Academy (Escondido, CA, 92025) presents as a school with a strong emphasis on parental involvement and structured, unit-based instruction typical of many home-education-anchored programs. Based on the school's public materials, the site evidences a clear commitment to independent study modeled learning with parents as the primary educators, a tracked program structure (Track A/B/C), and campus/-community activities (choirs, bands, field trips, and on-campus events). However, the site provides limited explicit articulation of the core Classical framework described in standard classical-literature rubrics, such as explicit reference to the Trivium (grammar, logic, rhetoric), Great Books, or explicit liturgical/theological practices, nor the explicit emphasis on Socratic pedagogy, scholé (restful learning), or the living-teacher as the "living curriculum." Consequently, while the site demonstrates some elements aligned with classical education (notably parent partnership and a culture of formation through structured units and community life), most of the canonical indicators in the classical rubric are not clearly evidenced in the site's public messaging. In aggregate, the school aligns with SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL signals in parts (notably Parent/Community engagement and structured, teacher-supported home instruction) but does not meet the dominant criteria across the six categories to be deemed fully CLASSICAL. The aggregate classification is NOT CLASSICAL, with one category (Parents & Community) showing notable alignment with classical ideals.

Key evidence driving this assessment includes:

- Clear presentation of an independent-study model with parents as the primary educators, supported by credentialed teachers. This is documented in The Classical Academy's public materials, including program descriptions and governance language.
- Explicit description of unit-based instruction, multiple program tracks, and home-based instructional options (Track A/B/C; C'lectives; Virtual Academy; Sora), demonstrating a highly structured approach but not a full classical curriculum vocabulary.
- Public materials emphasize parent partnerships and community/field experiences (family events, field trips, on-campus activities), which map cleanly to the classical Parents & Community category's positive indicators.
- Limited explicit references to classical curriculum elements (Great Books, Great Conversation, Trivium, Scholé, liturgical practices, or explicit Socratic pedagogy) in the accessible site content; the materials instead highlight California standards alignment and independent study. This reduces alignment with the Curriculum and Pedagogy categories in the classical rubric.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — **NOT CLASSICAL**

Evidence - Public materials focus on independent study, parent-led instruction, and standards alignment rather than explicit transcendent or theological foundations, liturgical practice, or metaphysical articulation. The site emphasizes structure, standards, and parental partnership rather than theology or liturgy.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords (per the Six Essentials lexicon for this category):

none clearly and directly evidenced on the public site (no clear mentions of truth, goodness, beauty as transcendent ideals, or liturgical practices). - Negative keywords: none clearly evidenced as explicit secular-morality/relativism signals in the public messaging.

Why this rating - The absence of explicit transcendental moral realism, theology, or liturgical/community worship language in the public materials supports a NOT CLASSICAL rating for this category.

Note: The main evidence lines come from the public-facing program and communication materials showing independent-study structure and parental leadership rather than theological or liturgical framing.

Element 2: Purpose and Goal — NOT CLASSICAL

Evidence - The messaging centers on academic achievement, structure, and parental collaboration rather than formation of virtue or true human flourishing as the telos of education. The stated aims emphasize thinking, communication, and achievement rather than a virtue-centered formation framework.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords (classical rubric): formation, virtue, telos, true/-good/beautiful, scholé, contemplation, moral imagination. These terms are not visibly foregrounded in the public materials. - Negative keywords: “workforce preparation emphasis,” “career readiness” language is not foregrounded; public materials emphasize independent study and standards rather than a job-oriented outcome. (No explicit negative signals observed in public messaging, though the absence of classical telos signals weighs against classical alignment.)

Why this rating - The school’s public focus on structure, online/home-based instruction, and standards-aligned units suggests a pragmatic, formation- or information-oriented approach rather than the formation of virtue and wisdom in the classical sense.

Note: Public content demonstrates a strong emphasis on achievement within a structured model, but not the transcendent aims of virtue and wisdom central to classical formation.

Element 3: Curriculum — NOT CLASSICAL

Evidence - Curriculum is described in terms of language arts, literature, math, science, and history, organized into units, with an emphasis on alignment to California Content Standards. The materials do not clearly describe Great Books, the Trivium/Quadrivium, or a global “Great Conversation” approach. Public materials do not consistently advocate for Great Books or classical core texts in the way classical schools typically frame curriculum.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords (classical elements): references to Seven Liberal Arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric), Great Books, or Great Conversation are not clearly evidenced in the public-site content. The presence is not demonstrated. - Negative keywords: The site does not emphasize project-based experiential learning as a primary pedagogy; however, that absence is a negative signal when measured against the Six Essentials’ explicit preference for Great Books, liberal arts, and a harmonized curriculum. The site foregrounds standard-based, unit-driven instruction rather than a classical liberal-arts curriculum.

Why this rating - Absent explicit Great Books emphasis, avoidance of the Trivium/Quadrivium, and lack of reference to a holistic liberal-arts structure in the public description place Curriculum in NOT CLASSICAL territory.

Evidence samples: description of units, core subjects, and California standards alignment.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — NOT CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public-facing materials describe a blended, tracked, and teacher-supported home-instruction model, with a focus on independent study led by parents and credentialed teachers. There is no explicit sustained evidence of Socratic seminars, scholé-based contemplative pedagogy, or formal memorization/recitation practices in the site text. The presence of on-campus choirs/band and field trips signals activity-based

programming but not the classical pedagogy markers (Socratic dialogue, chanting, rigorous formal rhetoric, or seated seminars).

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords: none clearly evidenced for Socratic dialogue, chant, or restfulness pedagogy; no explicit mention of scholé, rhetoric training, or structured orality beyond general instruction. - Negative keywords: absence of sustained engagement with memory-based recitation, chant, or liturgical/restful learning as core pedagogy is a missing signal in public messaging.

Why this rating - The public materials emphasize an independent-study model and track-based scheduling with parent leadership, rather than the classical pedagogical methods (Socratic seminars, memory work, or formal rhetoric training) typically highlighted in classical pedagogy sources.

Evidence: program options, independent study, unit planning, and parent-led instruction.

Element 5: Faculty — NOT CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public materials reference credentialed teachers supporting a parent-led instructional model, but there is no explicit articulation of the faculty as a “living curriculum,” mentorship culture, or teacher portraits in the school’s public messaging. The faculty role is described in practical terms (credentialed teachers, support for home instruction) rather than the classical ideal of teachers as moral exemplars and living curriculum.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords: “credentialed teachers” is present, which aligns with a professional teaching staff; but the classical lexicon emphasizes the teacher as a living curriculum and mentor. The public content does not explicitly present those classical portraits or mentorship framing. - Negative keywords: absence of explicit “portrait of a teacher,” “teacher as living curriculum,” or a “faculty of friends”—common classical signals.

Why this rating - While credentialed-teacher language is present, the strongest classical signals (teacher as exemplar, living curriculum, mentorship culture) are not clearly evidenced in public messaging.

Evidence: explicit mention of credentialed teachers and parent collaboration.

Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The public materials strongly emphasize parent partnership, with parents described as the primary educators and a central element of the instructional model. The school highlights open lines of communication with families, conferences, and joint responsibility for student progress. This aligns well with the classical emphasis on partnership with families, parental formation, and cultural transmission, even if the rest of the classical rubric is not fully present.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: Partnership with Families (parents as co-educators), parent formation, community involvement, and open communication; these map directly to the Six Essential Elements’ positive indicators for Parents & Community. - Negative keywords: The site does not reflect consumer-language dynamics or minimal parental involvement; rather it shows active partnership and family engagement.

Why this rating - The school’s explicit and sustained emphasis on parents as primary educators and on parental involvement demonstrates a strong alignment with the “Parents & Community” category’s classical indicators.

Evidence: “parents serve as the primary educators,” unit conferences, and family/community programs.

Aggregate assessment across all categories - Element 1: NOT CLASSICAL - Element 2: NOT CLASSICAL - Element 3: NOT CLASSICAL - Element 4: NOT CLASSICAL - Element 5: NOT CLASSICAL - Element 6: CLASSICAL

Overall classification: NOT CLASSICAL

What Would Move the Needle

- If the school is aiming to move toward CLASSICAL status, the following concrete steps would provide stronger alignment across multiple categories:
- Curriculum: Introduce explicit Great Books and the Great Conversation framework; clearly articulate the Trivium (grammar, logic, rhetoric) and Quadrivium elements in the curriculum; describe integration of liberal arts across history, literature, philosophy, and sciences.
- Pedagogy: Adopt a more explicit classical pedagogy (Socratic dialogue, disciplined memory work, chanting or recitation when appropriate, and opportunities for public rhetoric) and embed scholé (restful learning) into daily routines.
- Faculty: Develop a “living curriculum” model where teachers embody classical habits of mind and mentor students in virtuous learning; share a teacher-portrait or exemplar profile publicly.
- Purpose & Goals: Reframe mission statements to foreground transcendental aims (truth, goodness, beauty) and formation of character and wisdom alongside intellectual achievement.
- Religious & Metaphysical Foundations: If appropriate for the school’s ethos, more explicit integration of theological or metaphysical context (liturgical, communal practices, or spirituality that aligns with a classical understanding of education) should be referenced publicly, while respecting pluralism as applicable.
- Community & Partnership: Maintain and deepen strong parent partnership but add formal parent-formation programs (readings, seminars) that align with classical education, making explicit the co-educator role.

Note: The school already demonstrates strong Parents & Community alignment; further steps would primarily target Curriculum, Pedagogy, and explicit articulation of classical aims to elevate the overall CLASSICAL rating.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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